As a result, by 1980, the first battleground in the presidential contest was considered the Iowa caucuses, which were scheduled for January 21.

John Sears said polls indicated I had a comfortable lead in Iowa, where a lot of people still remembered me from my radio days, and so I didn't have to campaign much there. He kept me out of a debate sponsored by the *Des Moines Register and Tribune* that most of the candidates agreed to, and we ended up making only a handful of token appearances there instead of trying to visit all the communities in Iowa where they were going to have those meetings.

Well, as we discovered, it was a big mistake.

George Bush practically lived in Iowa before the caucuses (something I should have done) and he won the caucuses by a narrow margin.

This loss was a real shocker and a big disappointment to me. Even after all those years in Hollywood, I'd thought of Iowa as my adopted home state. Although a lot of years had gone by since I'd lived there, I considered myself a transplanted Iowan and had really expected to win. But we'd made the mistake of taking Iowa for granted; in a way, it was the 1976 New Hampshire primary all over again.

The day after the caucuses, most of the pundits agreed that by upsetting me George Bush now had the momentum to win the nomination—the "Big Mo," as George called it.

Suddenly for me the New Hampshire primary on February 26 loomed as a do-or-die contest. If Bush could beat me there, I knew—and everybody else on our team knew—it would be extremely difficult to ever get the campaign on a winning track.

The Iowa caucuses reminded me too much of my loss in New Hampshire four years earlier, when I'd left the state on the eve of the primary because of the advice I was ahead in the polls and didn't need to campaign there anymore.